Help them grow or watch them go toolkit

Thank you for investing in the continuous growth and development of your team. This toolkit is intended to be a practical resource to support you and your team members throughout the development journey.

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When to have a career conversation

For career conversations to be effective, focus on consistency rather than formality. Managers play an important role in creating space for these discussions and recognizing when they should happen — and they should not be limited to year-end performance reviews.

Instead, career conversations are most effective when they happen regularly and naturally over time. They can take place in a variety of moments, including brief check-ins during 1:1 meetings, whenever there is an opportunity to reflect, explore goals or support development.

At the end of the day, career conversations can happen at any time. Here are a few specific cues leaders can watch for as natural opportunities to start a development-focused conversation:

- When a team member expresses interest in learning something new
- When responsibilities or expectations shift
- When confidence is low or concerns are shared
- When starting or completing a project or assignment
- When a team member is passed over for an opportunity
- When a milestone, credential or recognition is achieved
- When engagement noticeably increases or declines
- When performance trends up or down
- When the team member seems to be struggling
- When things are going especially well or especially poorly

GETTING STARTED

Starting the first conversation is an important step, and each subsequent discussion becomes more productive as it builds on established understanding. Here are some suggestions on how to get started:

- "I want to make sure we're talking not just about day-to-day work, but also about your growth and where you'd like to go."
- "I'd love to use part of our 1:1 today to learn more about what's energizing you, what you want more of and how I can better support your development."
- "I realized we do a good job talking about the work in front of us, but I also want to make space to talk about your longer-term development."
- "I'd like to check in on how you're feeling about your growth, what you're enjoying and where you may want to stretch next."
- "I'd like us to start having more regular career conversations so I can more intentionally support your development"

QUESTION SUGGESTIONS

The questions below are intended to help you start meaningful career conversations with your direct reports. They are organized into four areas: **getting to know your team member more broadly, clarifying career goals, preparing for a growth opportunity and debriefing an opportunity to support intentional development.**

These prompts are meant to serve as inspiration and guidance, not a script. Feel free to choose the questions that are most relevant and tailor them to what will be most helpful for each team member.

Get to know your team member

Use these questions to better understand what energizes your team members, what matters to them and how they experience their work. Really knowing your team members beyond the work they produce can lay a good foundation for determining growth and development options.

ENERGY, ENGAGEMENT AND SATISFACTION

- Over the past few months/year, which parts of your job have brought you the most energy or enjoyment?
- Over the past few months/year, which parts of your job have felt draining or disengaging?
- What was the best part of this quarter/year for you?
- What work this past quarter/year did you find most satisfying?
- When have you felt most stretched lately? How did that feel?
- At what points have you noticed your energy or engagement dropping?

STRENGTHS AND TALENTS

- What have you always naturally been good at?
- What strengths do you feel you use most in your current role?
- What talents do you want to use more often?

VALUES AND MOTIVATORS

- Looking back, what has always been most important to you in work?
- What kinds of issues, problems or outcomes do you care most about?
- What are the top values that guide your decisions and choices?

INTERESTS AND PREFERENCES

- What do you enjoy learning about most?
- What do you wish you had more time to work on?
- What aspects of past roles or projects have you enjoyed most?
- What kind of work do you naturally gravitate toward?

DISLIKES AND DEVELOPMENT AREAS

- What type of work do you tend to avoid?
- What tasks often fall to the bottom of your to-do list?
- What kinds of work tend to bore or frustrate you?
- What lessons do you find yourself learning over and over again?
- How can your strengths sometimes work against you?
- What skills do you admire in others that you want to strengthen in yourself?

Clarify growth goals

Use these questions to understand more specifically where the team member wants to go and what development would be most meaningful.

FUTURE DIRECTION

- What are some of your longer-term career goals?
- What would you like more of in your work?
- What would you like less of in your work?
- What kinds of opportunities are you most interested in exploring?
- What skills or experiences do you want to build next?

CAPABILITY BUILDING

- To move toward your goals, what skills or knowledge do you need to build?
- What capabilities will be most important for your future success?
- What gaps do you think exist for you right now?
- What do you need to learn to get ready for what you want next?
- What experiences would help you grow most?

LEARNING FROM OTHERS

- Who is especially strong in the area you want to grow in?
- Whose work do you admire in that space?
- Which teams or groups have experience that could help you learn?
- Who might be able to mentor you, coach you or help you explore this further?

Prepare for a growth experience

Once a growth experience is identified (whether it's a stretch assignment, job shadow, formal learning program or anything else), use these questions to help the team member prepare intentionally.

- How will this opportunity help you move toward your career goals?
- What specifically do you hope to gain from this experience?
- What skills or insights are you hoping to build?

- How will you apply what you learn?
- What challenges or obstacles do you expect?
- How will you handle those challenges if they come up?
- What are you willing to invest to make the most of this opportunity?
- What support do you need from me?

Debrief and apply the learning

After a growth experience, use reflection questions to help the team member turn experience into development.

- What did you learn from that experience?
- In what ways were you challenged or stretched?
- What obstacles or pitfalls did you encounter?
- What helped you succeed, or what got in the way?
- What would you do differently next time?
- What did you discover about yourself through the process?
- What principles, lessons or takeaways will you carry forward?
- How can you apply this learning in the future?
- How can you use this learning in other situations or contexts?
- What is the biggest takeaway for you?

Growth and development ideas

OWNERSHIP AND LEADERSHIP

Team member concern	Leader suggestion	Why it helps
Wants people leadership experience	Suggest onboarding new team members, mentoring, coaching peers, leading team meetings, leading a project or joining an EBRG leadership team.	Builds leadership experience without needing a formal title change. Provides leadership practice before moving into formal people management.
Wants more ownership	Suggest ownership of a process, KPI, initiative or recurring team need.	Builds accountability, judgment and confidence.
Seems ready for more complexity	Suggest a high-visibility, ambiguous or broader initiative.	Prepares the team member for larger scope and more advanced roles.

EXPOSURE AND CONNECTION

Team member concern	Leader suggestion	Why it helps
Feels siloed	Suggest cross-functional meetings, shadowing or gig work with another team.	Builds relationships, broadens perspective and increases understanding of how work connects across the business.
Wants more visibility	Suggest presenting in meetings, sharing updates or representing the team in broader forums.	Increases exposure and helps others recognize the team member's contributions.
Interested in a new area of the business	Suggest job shadowing, cross-functional projects or meetings with leaders in that area.	Gives practical exposure and helps the team member explore interest before making a bigger move.
Needs broader business acumen	Suggest enterprise initiatives, business updates or cross-functional problem solving. Involve them in the budgeting process.	Deepens understanding of how the organization works beyond their immediate role.
Feels disconnected from purpose or the bigger picture	Suggest involvement in broader team discussions, business reviews or strategic initiatives.	Helps connect day-to-day work to larger business priorities.
Wants to expand their network	Suggest joining an EBRG, finding a mentor or participating in enterprise events. Suggest community involvement or volunteering their time.	Expands relationships, support systems and visibility across the organization.

GROWTH AND SKILL BUILDING

Team member concern	Leader suggestion	Why it helps
Wants to build new skills	Suggest training, certification, peer learning or a project that uses the skill. Suggest community involvement like joining a board.	Turns learning into practical capability through direct application.
Wants stronger strategic thinking skills	Suggest helping with planning, business cases or work tied to business priorities. Have them gather and analyze data to make a data-informed recommendation to the team.	Builds the ability to think beyond execution and connect work to outcomes.
Wants stronger communication skills	Suggest presenting to the team, facilitation or leading a knowledge-sharing session.	Strengthens clarity, confidence and executive presence.
Wants stronger influence skills	Suggest stakeholder-heavy projects, change management projects or leading without direct authority.	Builds the ability to align others, gain buy-in and navigate different perspectives.
Wants project management experience	Suggest owning a project plan, timeline or continuous improvement effort.	Develops coordination, prioritization and execution skills.
Lacks confidence	Suggest a manageable stretch assignment with support and visibility.	Builds confidence through achievable wins and supported growth.

CAREER DIRECTION AND ENGAGEMENT

Team member concern	Leader suggestion	Why it helps
Feels stuck in role	Suggest a stretch assignment, special project or focused development plan.	Re-energizes growth and helps the team member build next-step skills.
Unsure about next career step	Suggest career conversations, informational interviews or exposure to other functions.	Creates clarity and helps the team member explore possible paths.
Seems bored or unchallenged	Suggest a new assignment, problem-solving effort or work outside normal scope. Cross-train or rotate team's work, so team members get to experience different work on the team.	Introduces novelty and helps re-engage motivation. Rotating team's work also helps efficiently ensure coverage when a team member is out on leave.
Has a new interest they want to explore	Suggest a related project, pilot, course or connection with someone in that space. Have them research industry trends and present back to the rest of the team.	Encourages engagement while helping test and build a new interest.

Responding to challenging situations

Below are some situations you may encounter and not know how to respond, so we've provided sample responses to guide your approach. Use these as a starting point and adapt them to your style and the individual. The goal is to lead clear, honest conversations that support both performance and growth.

Reminder: If you're unsure how to approach a situation, your HR business partner can be a valuable partner and guide you in how to respond to your team member.

Team Member Situation	Sample Leader Response
A team member approaches you wanting a promotion, but there are no opportunities available	"I appreciate you coming to me with this – it shows you're thinking about your growth, and that matters. Right now, there isn't an open position, but that doesn't mean we can't work on your development. Let's talk about what's driving your interest in promotion. Is it the work itself, the scope of impact, compensation or recognition? Understanding that helps us find ways to support your growth even without a title change. In the meantime, we can focus on building the skills and experiences you'd need when an opportunity does open up. What specific capabilities do you want to develop? Let's create a plan that prepares you to be the obvious choice when the time comes."
A team member wants to grow, but they are under-performing.	"I'm glad you're thinking about your development – that growth mindset is important. Before we talk about new opportunities, I need to be direct with you about where things stand right now. There are some gaps in your current performance that we need to address first. [Be specific about 1-2 concrete examples] Here's what I'm thinking: let's focus on strengthening your performance in your current role over the next [timeframe]. That actually is your development plan right now – and it's the foundation for everything else you want to do. I'm committed to supporting you through this. What do you think is getting in the way of your performance? And what support do you need from me?"
A team member wants a stretch opportunity, but they are already at capacity.	"I love that you're eager for stretch opportunities – that tells me you're ready to grow. I want to be honest: I'm seeing you at full capacity right now, and I'm concerned about adding more to your plate. Taking on something new when you're already stretched thin usually means either the new thing suffers, your current work suffers or you do.

	Let's look at this differently. What if we identified one of your current responsibilities that could be a stretch opportunity if approached differently? Or, are there things on your plate we could shift, delegate or stop doing to create space? I want to support your growth and set you up to succeed. What matters most to you about getting a stretch opportunity right now?"
A team member was passed over for an opportunity and is discouraged.	“I want to help you be ready for the next time an opportunity comes up. Based on the gap between where you are and where you need to be, what if we identified some stretch assignments that would give you the specific experience you're missing? For example, [suggest 1-2 concrete possibilities: leading a cross-functional project, taking ownership of a key customer relationship, representing the team in segment meetings, solving a complex problem that requires the skills they need to build]. I also want to think about visibility and relationships. Who do you need exposure to? What experiences would strengthen your candidacy? Let's build a development plan together that's specifically designed to prepare you for the next opportunity like this. When it comes around again, I want you to be the obvious choice."
A team member wants development opportunities, but business priorities require them to stay focused on core responsibilities.	"I hear that you're ready for development opportunities, and I want to support that. Right now, we're in a period where the business needs us laser-focused on [specific priority]. I need to be honest - for the next [timeframe], your core responsibilities have to be the priority. That said, development doesn't have to stop. What if we looked at how you could develop within your current work? For example, you could [lead a process improvement, mentor someone, take on a different aspect of the project, build a new skill that enhances current work]. Also, let's talk about what you can do on your own time - reading, online learning, networking. And let's set a specific time to revisit this when bandwidth opens up. Does [specific date/milestone] work to check back in?"
A team member wants career guidance but resists honest feedback about gaps.	"I appreciate that you're asking for career guidance - that shows you're thinking about your future. Here's where I'm stuck: you're asking me to help you grow, but when I share feedback about areas to develop, I'm sensing resistance. Help me understand what's happening there.

	Career growth requires us to be honest about both strengths and gaps. I can't guide you effectively if we can't talk openly about both. My job isn't to judge you - it's to help you see your blind spots so you can address them. The feedback I'm sharing isn't about your worth as a person; it's about specific skills or behaviors that will matter for where you want to go. Here's something that might help: what if you gathered feedback from multiple sources through a 360-degree assessment? You'd hear from peers, direct reports if you have them and others you work with - not just from me. Sometimes it's easier to hear patterns when they're coming from several people, and it can help you see which feedback is about my perspective versus themes that others are noticing too. It would give you a fuller picture and help you own your development in a different way. Would a 360 assessment feel like a useful step to help you get broader input on your development areas?"
A team member wants more exposure to leadership but currently lacks a strong executive presence.	"I'm glad you're interested in more leadership exposure - that ambition is important. I want to be direct with you about something: right now, your executive presence isn't where it needs to be for the kind of visibility you're seeking. Let me be specific about what I mean. [Give 1-2 concrete examples: communication style, how they handle pressure, how they show up in meetings, etc.] The good news is that executive presence is absolutely something you can develop - it's not something you either have or don't have. Here's what I'm thinking: let's work on building these skills in lower-stakes environments first. [Suggest specific opportunities: leading team meetings, presenting to your peer group, getting a communication coach, observing senior leaders]. As I see you strengthen in these areas, I'll start creating opportunities for broader exposure. Does that feel like a fair path forward?"

Resources



Much of this content is leveraged from the book "Help Them Grow or Watch Them Go" by Beverly Kaye and Julie Giulioni.

Need some help with your conversations? Try out our Performance Feedback Coach custom GPT.

Talent and Culture SharePoint: View resources for the below areas.

TALENT STRATEGY AND TALENT MANAGEMENT

- Performance Management (Goal Setting, Mid-Year Check-in, Annual Review)
- Talent Calibration
- Succession Planning

LEARNING AND DEVELOPMENT

- Oshkosh Leadership Traits
- Leadership development programs: explore Oshkosh leadership programs and their criteria.
- Career development
  - Find a mentor
  - Requesting a 360-degree feedback assessment
  - Fuel your career journey: self-guided development journey in Workday based off the 70-20-10 development model created to support office team members in taking a more active role in their career growth, connecting team members to development tools, learning and experiences.

TEAM MEMBER EXPERIENCE

- Employee Business Resource Groups (EBRGs): voluntary, employee-led groups that bring team members together around shared backgrounds, interests or goals. They're a great way to build connections, grow leadership skills and make a positive impact.
- Peakon Team Member Experience Survey